ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Student Budgeting and Saving: Make Your Allowance Last the Month

A simple budget you can keep on your phone, and rules for spending decisions

MONEY & CAREER

Money & Career

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Running out of money mid-month is usually a planning problem rather than an income problem. This pack shows you how to track spending for one week, build a realistic monthly budget, separate needs from wants, and create a small emergency fund without pretending rice is optional.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Track actual spending and identify waste without guilt.
- Build a monthly budget based on real categories and costs.
- Apply a rule for separating needs, wants and emergencies.
- Start a modest emergency fund and avoid predatory borrowing.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Know where the money goes

You cannot budget what you have not measured. Track for seven days before changing anything.

- Record every payment, including small transport and data top-ups.
- Group spending into food, transport, data, accommodation, academic materials, social and other.
- Compare planned and actual totals at the end of the week.
- Find the leak categories: often snacks, unplanned outings and duplicate data bundles.
- Keep tracking for a month before making big changes.
- A notebook works; a spreadsheet or notes app works too.

Build the budget

A budget is a plan for money you have, not a wish list.

1. Estimate total monthly income: allowance, support, side income.
2. Put fixed costs first: rent, transport, feeding, data, academic materials.
3. Set a realistic food figure using actual meal costs, not wishful numbers.
4. Allocate a small social and discretionary amount deliberately.
5. Set aside a fixed amount for savings and emergencies before spending.
6. Adjust after the first month using real data, not optimism.

> **Pay yourself first**
> Move the savings amount out of the spending account at the start of the month. What remains is the budget; savings are not what is left over.

Saving and borrowing rules

Small, consistent savings beat occasional large intentions.

- Aim for a small buffer that covers transport, food and one unexpected cost.
- Use a separate account or wallet so the money is less visible.
- Never borrow to fund a want; borrow only for a genuine emergency.
- Avoid loan apps with short tenors and extreme fees.
- Never guarantee a loan for a friend or share your account details.
- Review your budget monthly and keep one record of what worked.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why track spending before budgeting?

Answer: Actual data reveals real costs and leaks; budgets built on guesses usually fail in week two.

2. What is 'pay yourself first'?

Answer: Setting aside savings at the start of the month before discretionary spending begins.

3. Give two examples of want disguised as need.

Answer: A second pair of fashionable shoes and an upgraded phone when the current one works.

4. Why are short-tenor loan apps risky?

Answer: They often carry very high fees and penalties, and easy access encourages borrowing for non-essential spending.

5. What should an emergency fund cover?

Answer: Unexpected costs such as medical treatment, emergency transport or replacing a lost essential item.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Track every expense for seven days.
- [ ] Categorise spending and find three leaks.
- [ ] Build a monthly budget with fixed and variable costs.
- [ ] Open a separate savings wallet or account.
- [ ] Set a fixed monthly savings amount.
- [ ] Review the month honestly and adjust one category.
- [ ] Write a personal rule for borrowing.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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